

MGMT 35200: Strategic Management
Spring Session 2026

Professor: Anthony Gibbs, Ph.D. (he/him)

Email: ragibbs@purdue.edu (I respond to emails within 24 hours on weekdays or on Monday for those received just before or during a weekend. Please use MGMT 352: in the subject line so I can recognize a message is for class.)

Cell: 443-540-4548 (Text before calling to let me know you are a student, as I have to filter unknown numbers for spam.)

My Office: RAWL 4036

My Office Hours: 2:00pm—4:00pm Tuesday and Thursday or email me to set up an appointment

Instruction Modality: Face-to-Face

Credit Hours: 3.00

Prerequisites: ECON 25100

Course Reference Numbers (CRNs):

Section 003: 10065

Section 005: 10069

Section 004: 10066

Meeting Days/Class Time/Room:

(Section 003) 9:00am – 10:15am Tuesday/Thursday – BRWN 1154

(Section 005) 12:00pm – 1:15pm Tuesday/Thursday – HAMP 1144

(Section 004) 4:30pm – 5:45pm Tuesday/Thursday – STEW 314

Hardware Requirements: Access to Brightspace for class material and communication

Course Overview

The course focuses on understanding competitive forces and how organizations strive to build sustainable competitive advantages through business- and corporate-level strategies. It integrates and builds upon previous training in functional areas and presents new analytical tools for developing an understanding of the strategic decisions that determine future directions and effectiveness of the organization. This course will train you to think as a strategic manager. You will learn frameworks to understand how firms create value, how competition between firms can spur more of this value creation, and how firms can constructively, ethically, and effectively compete with one another. You will study both *corporate*-level strategy, which focuses on the scope of the firm and in what industries and markets you will compete, and *business*-level strategy, which focuses on how to best compete in the chosen areas by leveraging differentiation or cost advantage.

Required Reading

Textbook: *Strategic Management, Concepts* by Frank T. Rothaermel, 6th Edition ISBN: 1265958092. Note that 5th edition is also fine and may be less expensive than the 6th.

Harvard Business Press cases and simulations: These can be obtained individually from the Harvard Business Publishing website: <https://hbsp.harvard.edu/import/1370443>

1. Yoffie and Kim (2010) Case #711-462: **Cola Wars Continue: Coke and Pepsi in 2010;**
2. Rothaermel and King (2023) Case #MH0079: **The Walt Disney Company;**

3. Khanna and Rangan (2005) Case #505-078: **Narayana Hrudayalaya Heart Hospital: Cardiac Care for the Poor (A)**;
4. Hagiü (2011) Case #712-416: **Wii Encore?**;
5. Shih and Kaufman (2014) Case #615-007: **Netflix in 2011**.
6. Wu and Yang (2025) Case #725484: **AI Wars in 2025**;
7. Rothaermel (2015) Case #MH0035: **Merck & Co., Inc.**

Learning Outcomes

On completing this course, students will be able to:

1. Develop and practice diagnostic reasoning skills relevant to problems of strategic management.
2. Learn and practice communicating your reasoning and judgments related to problems of strategic management - both through face-to-face listening and persuading, and through writing formal strategic analysis reports.
3. Understand the conceptual frameworks that will guide you in framing the relevant issues in a strategic situation.

To accomplish the learning outcomes, students will be trained to:

1. Understand core concepts of strategy, economic activity, and causal reasoning.
2. Analyze the internal structure of the firm and its fit with the external environment.
3. Systematically assess a firm's strategy and competitive advantage in relation to other firms at both the business (how to compete in one product market) and corporate level (which markets to compete in).
4. Formulate business- and corporate-level strategies to address opportunities and challenges facing modern organizations.

Grading

The Daniels School of Business has established target GPA grading guidelines that will be applied to this course. The average GPA for the section will be approximately 3.00 and all assignments will be normalized relative to other students in the class. For each of the categories of assignments below, there will be a performance distribution for the class by performance and curved grade assigned. The specific distribution will depend on raw performance, but here is an example of such a distribution:

Sample Curving Distribution (note, this may differ from assignment to assignment based on distribution of raw performance)

Assessment category:	Letter Grade	Percentage of maximum points awarded
95th or greater percentile	A+	100%
85-94th percentile	A	95%
75-84th percentile	A-	91%
60-74th percentile	B+	88%
40-59th percentile	B	85%
20-39th percentile	B-	81%
10-19th percentile	C+	78%
5-9th or lower percentile	C	75%
4th or lower percentile	C-	70%

Students whose performance falls far short of expectations	D or F	From 0% to 65% according to professor's discretion
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The above example assumes that everyone in the class exhibits satisfactory-level work. Everyone who has made it this far in your studies should achieve with a reasonable level of work, and I do not anticipate many cases otherwise. If, however, a student does not complete an assignment, submits an assignment late, gives minimal or no effort, etc., I will revise the assignment grade downward, which could go as low as zero percent. In this case, the lower performer will create opportunity for those with higher grades, as more students could receive higher grades while still maintaining the 3.00 GPA average. **Please be aware that final grades are not subject to negotiation**, as I believe that unfairly benefits aggressive advocacy rather than performance.

Assessment Categories	Maximum Points / Weighting
Attendance/Participation	20
In-class quizzes	25
Group Presentation	25
Final Exam	30
Total Weighting	100

Grading Scale	
Final Letter Grade	Points
A+	96 – 100
A	93 – 95.99
A-	90 – 92.99
B+	86 – 89.99
B	83 – 85.99
B-	80 – 82.99
C+	76 – 79.99
C	73 – 75.99
C-	70 – 72.99
D	60 – 69.99
F	0 – 59.99

Assessments

Attendance / Participation (20 points): Attendance in class is required. Students with the fewest unexcused absences will be ranked higher and those with the most unexcused absences will be ranked lower in this category. To set a fair baseline for this, unexcused absences will begin to count starting January 16th (as students are still adding classes up until this point). Students with more than 10 unexcused absences will receive unsatisfactory performance ratings and be graded an F for the entire category of attendance/participation.

To incentivize participation as well as attendance, after each class period beginning January 27th, I will keep track of how much students contributed value to class discussion and assign participation points. At the end of the semester, the participation points will be averaged over the classes attended (so excused absences will not count against you). Attendance and participations will be equally weighted and the category will be curved by percentile as normal.

To have the best chance to be awarded higher participation value:

- Preparation: Be prepared by thoroughly reading and thinking about the assigned readings
- Listening: Be an active listener during class discussion
- Speaking: Be an active contributor to class discussion

Active contribution means engaging in meaningful, insightful, and respectful interaction. Being a jerk or taking up far too much airtime is not active contribution, and in fact can/will count against you if it is disruptive to learning. Also, contributing the most value is not about having the “right” answer or agreeing with me—it is about critically thinking and applying the tools and your own experience.

In-Class Quizzes (25 points): For almost all class sessions beginning with January 27th, a quiz will be given. This will often be at the beginning of class, in which case, the quiz must be turned in after the first 10 minutes of class (this is explicitly a hard deadline to incentivize you to show up to class on time). Each quiz will focus on the reading assignment for that particular day, but may integrate topics from previous readings. During the 10 minute quiz period, students will be allowed to use a single page, front only of handwritten notes (a cheat sheet). This cheat sheet will be handed in with your quiz so if you want to keep a copy for later studying take a photo of it before the quiz starts. No electronic devices or other aids are allowed during the quiz. Performance percentiles will be ranked at the end of the course covering all quizzes.

Group Project (25 points): You will work in a team to analyze one important strategic question that a company is facing. Your team is responsible for both developing the question and answering the question. The presentation is meant to be directly to the board or to the CEO, as if you were hired as independent consultants. I will assign you randomly into a group of 4-6 members. With your group, you will choose:

1. A firm
2. An important strategic question, issue, or challenge that is currently facing the firm.

Your project will have three related outputs: (1) a list of initial ideas of potential companies / questions you may select; (2) an initial plan simulating an internal briefing on the firm, strategic question, and approach to answering it; and (3) a final video presentation simulating a client briefing to the board or CEO of the chosen company.

Below is a general guideline for the timeline of your course project:

- By week 8: Come up with 5 potential companies and questions of interest individually
- Weeks 8-9: Identify a target firm; identify the key question of interest
- Weeks 10-11: Create initial project plan
- Weeks 12-13: Data collection and analysis
- Week 14: Presentation prep
- Weeks 15: Record and submit video of final presentations

Final Exam (30 points): There will be a comprehensive final exam integrating all concepts and frameworks learned in the course.

Course Schedule

Module 1: Course Overview

Date	Topic	Reading Required
Tuesday, January 13	Introduction	The course syllabus
Thursday, January 15	What is Strategy?	Rothaermel, Chapter 1

Module 2: Causal Inference and What Went Wrong with Target Canada

Date	Topic	Reading Required
Tuesday, January 20	Causal Inference	Article on Brightspace
Thursday, January 22	Case Study	Mini-case: Target Canada

Module 3: External / Industry Analysis

Date	Topic	Reading Required
Tuesday, January 27	Industry Structure	Rothaermel, Chapter 3
Thursday, January 29	Case Study	Cola Wars Case

Module 4: Resource-Based View of the Firm

Date	Topic	Reading Required
Tuesday, February 03	Resource-Based View	Rothaermel, Chapter 4
Thursday, February 05	Flex Day (No Class)	
Tuesday, February 10	Case Study	Disney Case
Thursday, February 12	Flex Day (No Class)	

Module 5: Positioning – Cost Leadership vs. Differentiation

Date	Topic	Reading Required
Tuesday, February 17	General Strategies: Differentiation and Cost Leadership	Rothaermel, Chapter 6
Thursday, February 19	Case Study	Narayana Hrudayalaya Case

Module 6: Innovation Ecosystem

Date	Topic	Reading Required
Tuesday, February 24	Innovation and Platforms	Rothaermel, Chapter 7
Thursday, February 26	Case Study	Nintendo Wii

Module 7: Disruptive Innovation

Date	Topic	Reading Required
Tuesday, March 3	Disruptive vs. Sustaining Innovation	Rothaermel, Chapter 7
Thursday, March 5	Case Study	Netflix

Module 8: The Disruption of Generative AI

Date	Topic	Reading Required
Tuesday, March 10	Generative AI and Disruption	TBD
Thursday, March 12	Case Study	AI Wars in 2025

Intermission

Date	Topic	Reading Required
Tuesday, March 17	<i>Spring Break! No Class!</i>	
Thursday, March 19		

Module 9: Integration and Diversification

Date	Topic	Reading Required
Tuesday, March 24	Vertical Integration and Diversification	Rothaermel, Chapter 8
Thursday, March 26	Flex Day (No Class)	

Module 10: Mergers, Acquisitions, and Strategic Alliances

Date	Topic	Reading Required
Tuesday, March 30	Build, Borrow, Buy...	Rothaermel, Chapter 9
Thursday, April 2	Case Study	Hulu (Disney 2) Case

Module 11: Resource Position Exit

Date	Topic	Reading Required
Tuesday, April 7	...or Bail	Divestitures, Chapter 1 and 2 (posted on Brightspace)
Thursday, April 9	Case Study	Triam White Paper (PepsiCo Case)

Module 12: Organizational Structure

Date	Topic	Reading Required
Tuesday, April 14	Organizational Structure	Rothaermel, Chapter 11
Thursday, April 16	Case Study	Merck & Co., Inc.

Group Project Intensive Week

Date		
Tuesday, April 21	Groups work on final project	
Thursday, April 23	Groups work on final project	

GROUP PROJECTS DUE 11:59pm on Sunday, April 26th

Quiet Week

Date	Topic	Reading Required
Tuesday, April 28	Flex Days (No Class)	
Thursday, May 30		

Expectations

Part of the value of this class is a chance to learn, reinforce, and practice norms in a corporate environment. I will attempt to communicate clearly and give you constructive feedback when you are violating a modern corporate norm. The goal of this is to give you the information on behaviors that may damage your reputation with your managers, colleagues, and direct reports in the future at a time when you are in a safe and supportive learning environment.

- Courteous use of technology. In my experience (and based on the research evidence) technology can present a pernicious distraction and detract from the cooperative learning environment. Researchers have found that these distractions do in fact interfere with learning and active participation. While the use of computers and phones will be permitted during class meetings, I expect you to make the responsible and respectful decision to minimize disruptions to your colleagues and your own learning. If you have critical communication to attend to, please excuse yourself and return when you are ready. For more information about the science behind the policy watch: youtu.be/WwPaw3Fx5Hk
- Be on time. It is inconsiderate to be late, and in a business environment, such disrespect can damage your reputation and relationships. Be on time to show your colleagues you respect them.
- Be prepared. Success in a business environment requires intense preparation for every meeting or event you attend. For this class, it means having thoroughly read (not skimmed) each assigned reading and having thought critically about the material and how it relates to the topics of the week.
- Be respectful. Your colleagues and I will show you respect, and we expect the same in return from you. It's okay to disagree with one another, but I will not tolerate disrespect of others in class. No jerks.

Use of Outside Materials Including Artificial Intelligence (AI) Tools

Rapidly advancing machine learning technologies, including large language model (LLM) applications, are an important force impacting current business strategies. In light of this, we will collaboratively use LLMs during group discussions and in-class assignments to help familiarize us with the current state of technology, its uses, and limitations.

Acceptable uses of AI tools:

- AI tools can be used in class when explicitly stated by the instructor (e.g., work in your groups with ChatGPT, Gemini, or Claude to come up with the best answer you can to the following question...).
- LLMs can also be used as a comprehension tool when studying the assigned material for class; however, you are still responsible for reading all of the assigned material. Please note that the quizzes given on each reading may cover elements from the reading that an LLM may omit when summarizing, so it will be in your best interest to have read everything thoroughly even if using such a tool.
- LLMs can be used as a study aid for the final exam. Please note, however, that no technology of any kind may be used during the exam itself.

Restrictions on AI tools and other materials:

- A 1 page, front-only handwritten sheet of notes (a cheat sheet) may be used for in-class quizzes. These notes will be the only materials from class allowed to be used on the quizzes. Students must create their own notes and may not copy or use another student's notes. These notes must be physically turned in to the professor at the end of the quiz. No other materials of any kind (including readings, notes, websites, AI tools, etc.) may be used during the in-class quizzes.
- Students will be allowed to create 2 sheets front and back (4 pages total) of handwritten notes that they can use on the final exam. These notes will be the only materials from class allowed to be used on the exam. Students must create their own notes pages and may not copy or use another student's notes. These notes must be physically turned in to the professor or proctor before leaving the exam room. No other materials of any kind (including readings, notes, websites, AI tools, etc.) may be used during the final exam.

Additional Resources and Policies

Mental Health and Well-being Purdue University is committed to advancing the mental health and well-being of its students. If you or someone you know is feeling overwhelmed, depressed, and/or in need of mental health support, services are available. For help, such individuals should contact Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS) at 765-494-6995 during and after hours, on weekends and holidays, or by going to the CAPS offices in West Lafayette or Indianapolis.

If you find yourself beginning to feel some stress, anxiety and/or feeling slightly overwhelmed, try Therapy Assistance Online (TAO), a web and app-based mental health resource available courtesy of Purdue Counseling and Psychological Services (CAPS). TAO is available to all students at any time by creating an account on the TAO Connect website, or downloading the app from the App Store or Google Play.

Emergency Preparedness In the event of a major campus emergency, course requirements, deadlines and grading percentages are subject to changes that may be necessitated by a revised semester calendar or other circumstances beyond the instructor's control. Relevant changes to this course will be posted onto the course website or can be obtained by contacting the instructors or TAs via email or phone. See Purdue's Information on Emergency Preparation and Planning.

Note: As each section of this course is in a different campus building, please review the specific Building Emergency Plan regarding evacuation routes and shelter-in-place locations.

Nondiscrimination Statement Purdue University is committed to maintaining a community that recognizes and values the inherent worth and dignity of every person; fosters tolerance, sensitivity, understanding, and mutual respect among its members; and encourages each individual to strive to reach his or her potential. A hyperlink to Purdue's full Nondiscrimination Policy Statement is included in the Academic Resources table on your Brightspace homepage.

Accessibility and Accommodations Purdue University strives to make learning experiences accessible to all participants. If you anticipate or experience physical or academic barriers based on disability, you are encouraged to contact the Disability Resource Center at: drc@purdue.edu or by phone: 765-494-1247, as soon as possible.

Testing Accommodations: Students with disabilities whose DRC Course Accommodation Letter (CAL) includes test accommodations must first release their CAL to me and then schedule to take their exams with Purdue Testing Services. You must schedule at least four days (96 hours) before the exam date listed on the syllabus. In the case of finals week, you must schedule by the Friday before Quiet Period. Students who fail to follow this process and meet stated deadlines risk not being able to have their accommodations for that exam.

Academic Integrity Incidents of academic misconduct in this course will be addressed by the course instructor and referred to the Office of Student Rights and Responsibilities (OSRR) for review at the university level. Any violation of course policies as it relates to academic integrity will result minimally in a failing or zero grade for that assignment, and at the instructor's discretion may result in a failing grade for the course. In addition, all incidents of academic misconduct will be forwarded to OSRR, where university penalties, including removal from the university, may be considered.